But the impact cannot be judged just in terms of problems or solutions; it is even more about mindset.

The implications for international relations are particularly far-reaching. The Covid experience has challenged the globalization model that had entrenched itself in the last three decades. The efficiency obsession has been balanced to a considerable degree by a hedging mentality, and the experience on the vaccine front has heightened awareness in the Global South about its interests.

This pandemic may be the most serious in living memory, but it should be seen as a recurring challenge and not a one-off. It demands cooperation on a scale that could not have been conceived of earlier. No national capacity, however large, proved to be adequate. And merely excess volumes from even the large capacities are not clearly enough to address global needs. A collective response, by itself, could fall short if it is just an aggregate of the present capabilities. What we will now have to conceptualize is re-engineering of the way the world works to respond to such cataclysmic events. The pandemic has certainly triggered debates on issues like supply chains, global governance, social responsibility and even ethics. It equally encourages an objective assessment of the contemporary world, so that we are better prepared for tomorrow.

As nations contemplate the world, there is no question that Covid has moved the needle in the direction of fears. This is reflected in national security acquiring a more expansive definition. In the past, defence, politics and intelligence drove calculations, with extrapolation into domains like resources, energy and technology. With some notable exceptions, their demands were balanced out by the requirements of global exchanges, economic efficiency and by social habits. These trends, in fact, became stronger as the globalization mantra took deeper root.

The pandemic, however, saw capabilities leveraged, commitments dishonoured, supply chains blocked, logistics disrupted and shortages created. When this applied to PPE, medicines and ventilators, we woke up to health security. Those who saw their essential supplies under threat now realized the value of food security. Where economies slowed down due to material disruptions, we now understood the need for manufacturing security. Call it buying nationally, middle-class concerns, dual circulation or self-reliance; its underlying message is not that different. The efficiency of